



ECUADOR

Capital city: Quito**Area:** 109,483 sq miles (283,560 sq km)**Population:** 13,000,000**Official language:** Spanish**Major religions:** Christian 95%, other 5%**Government:** Multiparty democracy**Currency:** US dollar**Adult literacy rate:** 91%**Life expectancy:** 70 years**People per doctor:** 588**Televisions:** 293 per 1,000 people

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CUT THROUGH BY THE EQUATOR, after which it is named, Ecuador is a small country with a varied landscape. A journey of just 125 miles (200 km) takes you from humid coastal lowlands, up into the cold air of the Andes, and down into tropical rain forest. Ecuador also includes the Galápagos Islands, which lie about 620 miles (1,000 km) west in the Pacific Ocean. Ecuador has large reserves of oil and natural gas, and these products account for nearly half of the country's export earnings.



COTOPAXI

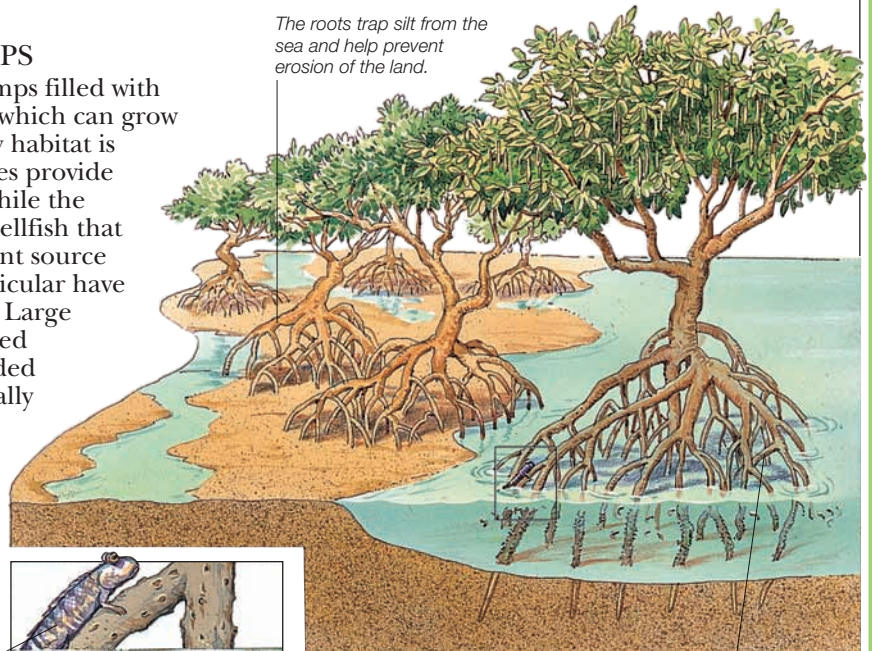
Ecuador is home to the notorious "volcano boulevard" – four rows of volcanic mountains that form part of the Andes chain. At least 10 of them are still active. One of the most famous is Cotopaxi. At a towering 19,348 ft (5,897 m) in height, this is one of the world's tallest active volcanoes. It last erupted in the early 1900s.

MANGROVE SWAMPS

Along the coast are swamps filled with trees called mangroves, which can grow in salt water. This watery habitat is very important – the trees provide firewood and lumber, while the fish, crustaceans, and shellfish that live here are an important source of food. Shrimps in particular have become a major export. Large shrimp farms have created thousands of much-needed jobs, but they are gradually destroying the coastal environment on which they depend.

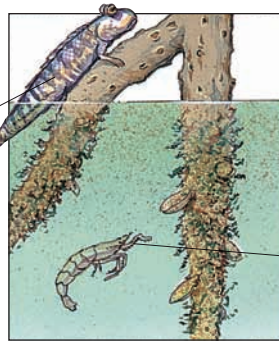
At high tide, the sea comes in and covers the roots.

The roots trap silt from the sea and help prevent erosion of the land.



The mangroves' tangled roots spread far and wide, some even emerging above water to trap oxygen.

Mudskippers are the only fish that can live on land and in the water.



Swamp water is usually very muddy.

Shrimps are washed in with the tide. They feed on plankton.

Panama hats are made from the leaves of the jipijapa plant.



AGRICULTURE

Twenty years ago, Ecuador's economy was based on three crops: bananas, coffee, and cocoa. Today, agriculture is less dominant, but about a third of the workforce still makes a living from farming. Fishing is also important, with shrimps, sardines, and tuna among the main catches. A recently introduced crop is cut flowers, such as roses, carnations, and statice, which are exported to North America and Europe.



THE OTAVALO INDIANS

The town of Otavalo, high in the Andes, is home to one of the wealthiest groups of Indians in South America. The Otavalo make blankets, ponchos, rugs, and other woven goods, which they sell to tourists and export all over South America, the US, and Europe.

Demand for Otavalo goods is so great that many of them are now mass-produced, using artificial dyes and fibers and machines for weaving. The money raised allows the Otavalo to continue their traditional way of life.



Otavalo rug, decorated with llamas



Otavalo market is so popular with tourists that it now occupies all five squares in the center of town.

PANAMA HAT

Panama hats have never been made in Panama. They come from Ecuador, where they were originally made for export to Panama – hence the name. A good-quality hat takes three months to make and can be rolled up without being ruined.

Find out more

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